

Key facts

COVID-19 is the greatest public health challenge in a century, with tens of millions of people infected and over a million deaths.

Countries of the Western Pacific Region have responded based on the *Asia Pacific Strategy for Emerging Diseases and Public Health Emergencies*.

WHO has supported Member States with technical and financial assistance, evidence-based guidance, communication and provision of supplies.

Since WHO was alerted to a cluster of cases of pneumonia of unknown cause in Wuhan, China on 31 December 2019, coronavirus disease 2019 (COVID-19) has been reported by **more than 200 countries**, territories and areas in the world. The Director-General declared a **public health emergency of international concern** – WHO's highest level of alarm under International Health Regulations – on 30 January 2020, when there were fewer than 100 cases and no deaths outside China.

Many Member States in the Western Pacific Region responded rapidly and effectively, thanks in part to capacity developed through 15 years of the *Asia Pacific Strategy for Emerging Diseases and Public Health Emergencies (APSED)*. Most Pacific island countries and areas have yet to report a single case.

Although numbers of cases and deaths in the Western Pacific have been the lowest among the WHO regions, the **impact of this pandemic has been enormous for families, societies and economies**. Some countries face a **shortage of essential supplies**, including personal protective equipment (PPE), diagnostics and **capacity for clinical management**.

We are entering a new phase of COVID-19 in the Region. Experiences in some countries indicate that COVID-19 continues to spread even in areas that have not detected the virus for weeks or months. Given the long-term response ahead, Member States need to explore **new and sustainable ways to suppress the infection and adapt to the new normal**, expanding capacity for early detection and targeted response, strengthening health systems and protecting vulnerable populations.

WHO response

Since the beginning of January, the three levels of WHO (country and regional offices and headquarters) have worked together to respond to COVID-19. In the first nine months of the response in the Western Pacific Region, WHO has:

- **deployed 185 experts to 12 countries**
- **mobilized US\$ 68.64 million** for the response
- **delivered US\$ 5.3 million** worth of supplies including **PPE, lab supplies and equipment**
- **worked with 312 operational partners**, 71 donors, 59 Global Outbreak Alert and Response Network (GOARN) partners, and 228 members of the Risk Communication and Community Engagement Asia Pacific Working Group
- responded to close to **600 media requests**
- scaled up the use of **social listening and behavioural insights** to inform risk assessment and decision-making, enhancing communications and community engagement
- **published 26 interim guidance documents** and two books to inform Member State responses.

The COVID-19 pandemic continues to raise many challenges, but it also presents opportunities to further strengthen health systems and create more resilient and equitable societies. As Member States and WHO continue to respond to COVID-19, we must work towards a new future, in which health, environment and economy are inseparable, and real investments back commitments to make the Western Pacific the world's safest and healthiest region.

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